

the shares were extremely illiquid. When first issued, no stock market even existed, and purchasers were expected to hold on to the shares for 21 years, the length of time granted to the company by the Netherlands' charter over trade in Asia. However, some investors wanted to sell their shares, perhaps to pay down debts, and so an informal market for the stock (the very first stock market) developed in the Amsterdam East India House. As more joint-stock equity companies were founded, this informal location grew, and was later formalized as the Amsterdam Stock Exchange, the oldest "modern" securities exchange in the world.² Despite the structure of the shares of the Dutch East India Company not changing much, their market liquidity and trading volumes changed considerably.

Similarly, when bitcoin, the first cryptoasset and therefore the crypto- analogue to the Dutch East India Company, was "issued" through the mining process, there was no market to transact or trade bitcoin. For much of 2009, there were hardly any bitcoin transactions, even though a new batch of 50 bitcoin was minted every 10 minutes. It wasn't until October 2009 that the first recorded transaction of bitcoin for the U.S. dollar took place: 5,050 bitcoin for \$5.02, paid via PayPal.³ This transaction was sent from one of Bitcoin's earliest proselytizers, Martti Malmi, to an individual using the name NewLibertyStandard, who was trying to set up the world's first consistent place of exchange between bitcoin and the U.S. dollar.⁴